THE PACK, THE ALPHA & THE ANCIENT CURSE

Core Lore — Unlocked progressively through Takoda, Marie, investigation Full picture never given in one place — assembled by Marcus across multiple sources

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THE ORIGIN — What Actually Happened

The Land Before Wroughtwood

The land that would become Wroughtwood was a threshold. Not metaphorically — literally. A place where the boundary between states of being ran thin. The tribe that tended it understood this. They built their practices around it. The boundary markers weren't decoration — they were maintenance. Active, intentional, generational work keeping the threshold from becoming a door.

When the army came, the tribe fought. They were losing.

The Deal

In desperation, the tribal elders made contact with something old. Older than the tribe. Older than the land's current shape. An ancient spirit — no name that translates, no form that holds still, no allegiance to anything living.

They asked it to drive the soldiers away.

The spirit looked at the soldiers — men moving across the land with weapons and horses and absolute certainty that everything in front of them was theirs to take — and made a decision.

They already behave like beasts, it reasoned. *Let them be what they are.*

This was not mercy. This was not help. This was the spirit's own amusement dressed as assistance. It did not consult the tribe on the terms. It simply acted.

The soldiers — forty-three men — transformed. Not all at once. Not the same way. But over the following nights, one by one, the men who had come to clear this land became something that couldn't hold a rifle or follow an order or remember why they'd come.

The Plague

The spirit's solution became the tribe's new problem immediately.

The transformed soldiers did not leave. They had no reason to leave. They had no orders, no destinations, no selves left to want things. They stayed on the land they'd been trying to take and they hunted it. And when they infected others — because they did, because the condition spreads — the numbers grew in ways the tribe hadn't anticipated.

The tribe fought back. They had knowledge of the land, the boundary markers, the threshold's properties. They knew things about what the spirit had made that the spirit hadn't told them. They found that certain materials, certain practices, certain places weakened the infected. They thinned the pack. Killed many.

But they could not find the alpha.

THE ALPHA — General Silas Cord

Silas Cord. Brigadier General. Forty-one years old when the spirit touched him. He had been leading the land-clearing operation — the man who gave the orders, who drew the maps, who wrote the dispatches back east describing the territory as empty and available.

He was the first. The spirit chose him first — the man with the most certainty, the most authority, the most complete belief that what he was doing was correct. Whatever the spirit did to Cord, it had five years of practice by the time the tribe found it. He was not like the others.

The pack are movie monster werewolves — bipedal, seven feet of muscle and wrong proportion, shaped like men the way a nightmare is shaped like a memory. They walk upright. They have hands. They are fast in the specific way of something large that has no reason to be that fast. Each one retains something of the person underneath — a posture, a habit of movement, a particular way of holding the head — which is the most disturbing thing about them. You can see what they were in the outline of what they became. Something that plans. Something that has been in those woods for over a century and has not gotten any less intelligent.

He is the alpha. He has always been the alpha. No one has ever taken that from him.

Transformed he stands eight feet or better — bipedal, massive, shaped like a man the way a cathedral is shaped like a house. The proportions are wrong in ways that accumulate: the shoulders too broad, the arms too long, the hands ending in fingers that are also claws without committing to either. Fur dark gray going silver at the chest and muzzle — the color of a uniform that has been through too many campaigns. His face retains the structure of a human face underneath the wolf's — a jaw that could bite through timber, a brow that still carries the particular set of a man accustomed to command. His eyes are the pale blue-gray they have always been. They are the worst part. You can see him in there. You can see that he knows you can see him.

He remembers his name. This is the most frightening thing about him.

The Weakening & The Removal

The tribe reduced the pack. They couldn't kill Cord — he was too old, too smart, too deeply rooted in the land's changed nature. But they contained him for a time, pushed the pack deep into the north woods, restored enough boundary markers to limit their range.

Then they ran out of time.

The remaining settlers — men and women who had come after the army, who didn't know what the army had become, who just wanted the land — saw a weakened tribe and made their own calculations. The tribe was driven off. The boundary markers they'd spent weeks restoring were pulled up within a year as the settlers cleared the land for fields.

With the markers gone, Cord's range expanded again.

The cycle — new arrivals, new infections, containment, loss, new arrivals — had begun.

THE PACK — Current Status

Total wolves: 15 + Alpha (Cord) = 16

The pack lives deep in the north woods where the land still holds the threshold's influence. Time moves differently there — not dramatically, not in ways that announce themselves, but a man who walks in at noon may come out believing only an hour has passed when three have gone. The pack uses this. They know the territory. They know where the shifts are. Outsiders get lost. The pack does not.

Pack Structure

Role	Number	Description
Alpha	1 — Cord	Never approaches town. Directs through the pack's instinct-bond.
Lieutenants	3	Oldest infected after Cord. Jacob Marsh is one. They retain more awareness than the others.
Pack body	11	Various infected across Wroughtwood's history. Range in age from 5 years infected to decades.
Curtis	1 — newest	Deliberately sought infection. Not fully turned yet. Still transitional.

Curtis — The Truth

> *This is the gut punch. Built toward across the entire game. Delivered at Takoda visit 5 or later investigation.*

Curtis did not stumble onto that road by accident.

He knew about the pack. Not everything — not the alpha's identity, not the full history. But enough. He had heard things, asked questions in places Marcus didn't know he was asking, and somewhere in the weeks before that night he made a decision.

Curtis wanted in.

Why? This is the question that will destroy Marcus when he finally asks it. The answers are assembled across multiple sources:

From Takoda — Visit 5: *"The alpha selects. He looks for people who are already reaching for something they cannot name. People who feel the limits of what they are."*

From Marie — if asked directly after CURTIS_WAS_CHOSEN: She is quiet for a long time. *"Your friend — he came to the edge of the swamp three weeks before you arrived. I watched him from the water."* She looks at the fire. *"He was looking for the path north. He'd been looking for a week."*

From Curtis himself — if Marcus reaches him before full turn: *"You don't understand what it's like. Being exactly what everyone expects. Being exactly as far as you're ever going to get."* A pause. *"I found something that could make me more."*

What Curtis Did That Night

Curtis knew approximately where the pack moved. He arranged the job — he chose that road, that night. He planned to encounter the pack, make contact, and begin the process deliberately.

What he did not plan was Marcus.

Marcus was supposed to stay in the car. Curtis had told Darnell the job needed two people specifically so Marcus would be there for cover — a legitimate reason to be on that road. Marcus was never supposed to get out.

When Marcus got out and walked toward the tree line, Curtis tried to stop him. *Don't stop, man — keep driving.* He was afraid. Not of what was in the woods. Of what would happen to Marcus if he went in.

He wasn't fast enough.

The pack found Marcus first. The infection doesn't negotiate — it doesn't ask who wanted it and who didn't. Marcus got bitten. Curtis — already partially in contact with the pack — was changed more rapidly in the chaos of what followed.

Curtis placed the watch. He put it near where Marcus fell. He remembers doing that. He remembers Marcus's name. He is the figure backlit on the full moon night. He is one of Jacob Marsh's lieutenants now.

He is still in there. Barely. Less every full moon.

CURTIS_FULL_TRUTH — assembled when Marcus has:

- CURTIS_WAS_CHOSEN (Takoda)
- MARIE_KNOWS_CURTIS (Marie)
- CURTIS_SHADOW_SIGHTING (full moon)
- One additional — either the watch flag or the memory fragment

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THE NORTH WOODS — Where Time Shifts

The pack's territory begins approximately a mile north of the attack site. The boundary is not marked — it is felt. Marcus's instincts register it before he consciously processes it. The air changes. Sound carries differently. Shadows fall at angles that don't match the light source.

Inside pack territory:

- **Time distortion:** Each hour inside feels like 45 minutes. Players who enter without awareness lose track of day/night transitions. Night can arrive suddenly.
- **Disorientation:** Standard navigation fails. The compass — Jacob's compass — works here. Nothing else does reliably.
- **Scent Trail ability required** to follow specific pack members
- **Pack Sense** activates continuously — Marcus always knows when something is nearby, but there is always something nearby
- **The deeper in, the older the land feels** — the threshold's original nature is strongest here. The boundary markers that remain are deep in this territory, intact, forgotten. Takoda knows where they are.

Cord's Location

General Silas Cord does not move from a central location in the deepest part of the territory. He hasn't needed to move in decades. He sends the pack. He waits. He has been waiting for over a century with the patience of something that has stopped experiencing time the way living things do.

His location is approximately two miles north of the attack site. The compass points there when it drifts. The maintained trail leads there. Scent Trail follows him there.

No one who has gone that deep has come back to Wroughtwood to describe it.

Except Takoda, who goes to the edge of that territory and no further, and who has never explained why he stops there.

TOWNSPEOPLE DISAPPEARING — Day 14+

By Day 14 the pack has become emboldened. The reasons are multiple:

- The moon phase is building toward full
- Marcus's presence has disturbed their established patterns — new infected, uncontrolled, moving through their territory and the town
- Cord has decided that fifteen is not enough. He is building toward something. He wants the numbers to mean something before the next full moon.

One person disappears the first night. Then one per night. The pack is not feeding — they are recruiting.

Pruitt's Questions — Day 15

Pruitt finds Marcus the morning after the second disappearance. He is alone. No badge theatrics, no public confrontation. He looks tired in the way of a man who has been not-sleeping for reasons he won't name.

"Two people gone in two nights," he says. *"Neither one of them the type to wander."*

He looks at Marcus.

"I'm not accusing you of anything," he says carefully. *"I'm asking you what you know."*

THE CELL RISK — based on accumulated flags:

Condition	Risk Level	Pruitt's Approach
PRUITT_REL: CORDIAL + BLACKOUT never visible	Low	He believes Marcus isn't responsible. Asks for help.
PRUITT_REL: WATCHED + 1 visible blackout	Medium	He's not sure. Asks hard questions. Wrong answers → cell.
PRUITT_REL: HOSTILE OR 2+ visible blackouts	High	He's already half-decided. Marcus needs specific flags to stay free.
CALHOUN_OWES_MARCUS set	Reduces risk by one level	Calhoun, of all people, tells Pruitt to leave him alone. Neither of them mentions why.

Player Choices — Pruitt's Questions:

A — Tell him what you know about the pack If PRUITT_KNOWS_PACK already set — he listens without surprise. *"I've known something was out there for years,"* he admits. *"Never let myself call it what it was."* If not — his face goes through several things in quick succession. He sits down. PRUITT_FULL_DISCLOSURE set — Pruitt becomes a limited ally in the endgame. HUMANITY +10

B — Tell him about Curtis specifically *"There's a man in those woods. He was with me the night I came in."* Marcus gives Pruitt Curtis's description. Pruitt makes a note. *"The missing man you mentioned when you arrived." "He's not missing. He's out there."* Pruitt looks at his notes for a long time. PRUITT_HUNTING_CURTIS set — Pruitt begins his own investigation of the north road. This has consequences.

C — Deflect — say you don't know anything If PRUITT_REL: CORDIAL — he doesn't believe it but lets it go. *"Alright. But you hear anything—"* If PRUITT_REL: WATCHED or worse — the quiet comes down. *"Come with me."* SECOND_CELL_RISK — Marcus spends the night in jail again. RAGE +15, HUNGER +20. The disappearances continue outside.

D — Tell him to talk to Harlan Doss Pruitt goes still. *"The old man on the field road." "He knows more than he's said."* Pruitt looks at Marcus for a long moment. *"How do you know that?"* PRUITT_INVESTIGATING_HARLAN set — accelerates CONTAINED thread if DOMINION_THREAD active.

MARIE ATTACKED — Day 16

Marcus is wherever he is when she comes to him. She comes to him — she does not send word, she does not wait for a visit. She finds him.

She looks the same as she always looks except for one thing — a long mark on her forearm, already healing faster than it should, the kind of mark that has a specific shape. Claw marks. Four of them.

She looks at the mark. Looks at Marcus.

"They came to the swamp last night," she says. *"Three of them. Testing."*

She says *testing* the way a general says it — with assessment and not alarm.

"They were not trying to kill me." A pause. *"They wanted to see what I would do."*

"What did you do?"

Something moves across her face. Not quite a smile.

"I reminded them why they don't come to the swamp," she says.

She looks north.

"But they will come back. Cord is moving them. He is building to something before the next full moon." She looks at Marcus. *"You need to find your friend before that moon rises. After it — he won't be findable anymore."*

MARIE_ATTACKED set CURTIS_DEADLINE_ACTIVE — the next full moon is the point of no return for Curtis

Marie begins actively tracking the pack from this point — moving at night through the swamp connection to the north woods, mapping their patterns. She will share what she finds with Marcus across daily check-ins if TRUST_MARIE is sufficient.

HARLAN — TELLING HIM WHAT'S HAPPENING

> *If Marcus goes to Harlan after Day 14 with information about the disappearances and the pack:*

Harlan listens. He asks specific questions — more specific than a concerned old man should know to ask. How many in the pack. How long the alpha has been present. Whether Marcus has seen Cord directly.

After Marcus finishes, Harlan is quiet for a long time.

"I need to make a call," he says.

He doesn't say to whom.

DOMINION_CALL_MADE set

THE CONTAINED ENDING — Information Threshold

> *The CONTAINED ending activates based on cumulative information shared with Harlan across the whole game. More information = more complete Dominion response.*

Information Shared	CONTAINED_THREAD Value Added
Harlan question in Marie's scene — detailed answer	+2
Marcus's own infection disclosed to Harlan	+3
Pack size and location described	+3
Alpha's identity — General Cord — disclosed	+4
Curtis's involvement described	+2
Takoda's existence disclosed	+3
Restoration possibility (boundary markers) disclosed	+2
Marie's identity and powers described	+3

CONTAINED_THREAD total determines Dominion's response scale:

Total	Dominion Response
0–5	Harlan files a minor report. No significant response before game ends.
6–10	Dominion sends two additional agents. They arrive late — after the climax. They clean up what's left. Marcus is on their list but escapes in the chaos.
11–15	Dominion arrives before the final confrontation. They quarantine the north woods. Pack engaged with military precision. Town survivors contained and silenced. Marcus captured.
16+	**FULL CONTAINED ENDING** — Dominion drops the hammer on Wroughtwood completely. See below.

THE CONTAINED ENDING — Full Resolution

Trigger: CONTAINED_THREAD 16+ AND DOMINION_CALL_MADE

Three black vehicles arrive in Wroughtwood on the night of Day 17. No markings. Men in dark clothing who move with the specific efficiency of people who have done this before. They do not introduce themselves to Pruitt. They show him something — a document, a badge, something that makes Pruitt step back and not speak again.

The town is told to stay inside.

The north woods are entered from three directions simultaneously.

The pack — outnumbered, outmaneuvered, cornered in territory that Dominion has clearly mapped in advance — is engaged. The sounds from the north woods last approximately forty minutes. Then silence.

Cord is the last. The sounds from Cord's location last longer. Then those too go silent.

The town of Wroughtwood is quarantined. Residents are interviewed — a word being used loosely. Those who know too much are relocated. The official story involves a gas leak. There are no journalists in Wroughtwood. There is no one to contradict the story.

Harlan Doss oversees the operation from the field's edge. He does not enter town. He never does.

Marcus is found the following morning.

He is not harmed. The men who collect him are professional and specific — they know his name, his origin, his infection timeline. They know about the watch. They know about Curtis. Harlan gave them a thorough file.

He is placed in a vehicle.

Final narration:

They don't tell you where you're going. You ask once and the man in the front seat doesn't turn around.

You look out the window at Wroughtwood receding. The field where you woke up. The road you walked in on. The sign you can't read anymore from this distance but know by heart.

Somewhere behind you in those woods, in the quarantine perimeter, something that used to be Curtis is being processed with the same clinical efficiency as everything else.

You think about the watch. Still in your pocket if you found it. Still ticking.

You think about what Marie said the first night.

"Whatever happened to you on that road — it doesn't have to be the whole story."

You're starting to think she was wrong about that.

Fade to black.

ENDING: CONTAINED *You trusted the wrong man with the right information. Wroughtwood is gone. So are you.*

SCENE NOTES

- **The spirit's motivation** — calling the soldiers beasts and making them so — is the moral center of the entire game's lore. It wasn't wrong exactly. But it wasn't help. It was judgment wearing the shape of assistance. Marcus should feel this when he learns it — because something is doing the same thing to him.
- **Cord remembering his name** is the detail that makes him irreducibly horrifying. Every other wolf has lost themselves to the animal. Cord never did. He has been General Silas Cord for over a hundred years. He still gives orders. He still thinks strategically. He just does it from the deep woods with claws and the patience of something immortal.
- **Curtis choosing this** lands differently than Curtis being taken because it implicates the friendship. Marcus didn't know his friend was suffocating in their shared life. He didn't know Curtis was reaching for something else. The watch — placed deliberately in the field — is the last thing Curtis did as himself. He couldn't undo what happened to Marcus. He could at least leave him something.
- **The CONTAINED ending's final line** — *you trusted the wrong man with the right information* — is the game's thesis statement about Harlan. He was never a villain. He was always exactly what he was. Marcus just didn't look at it straight.
- **Takoda stopping at the edge of Cord's territory** is never explained. The game doesn't need to explain it. Some things you don't walk toward.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
PACK_ORIGIN_KNOWN	Takoda visit 3
ALPHA_TRUE_NATURE	Takoda visit 4
ALPHA_IDENTITY_CORD	Takoda visit 4 + investigation cross-reference
CURTIS_WAS_CHOSEN	Takoda visit 5
CURTIS_FULL_TRUTH	All four Curtis flags assembled
CURTIS_DEADLINE_ACTIVE	Marie attacked, Day 16
MARIE_ATTACKED	Day 16, automatic
PRUITT_FULL_DISCLOSURE	Pruitt questions, Choice A
PRUITT_HUNTING_CURTIS	Pruitt questions, Choice B
SECOND_CELL_RISK	Pruitt questions, Choice C with bad standing
PRUITT_INVESTIGATING_HARLAN	Pruitt questions, Choice D
DOMINION_CALL_MADE	Marcus tells Harlan about pack activity
CONTAINED_THREAD	Running total — increments throughout game